

Buying Tips

Now that you've decided on what sort of camera you need, and are raring to part with some of that hard-earned cash, here's a few tips on doing it wisely.

- ❑ Don't fall for the Megapixel Myth. Megapixels ratings are important but are not the whole story. An 8-megapixel camera *can* produce substandard results as compared to a 5-megapixel camera—it's been tested and proved! The optics of a camera is what is most important. Then come the megapixel rating and the image processor. Generally, manufacturers give higher megapixel ratings to their better models; however, quality will differ across manufacturers with the MP rating kept constant.
- ❑ Brands of some significance. A bigger brand may have spent more on R&D, and chances are the quality of components used will be better. Bigger brands also offer better support as a general rule. Compatibility across memory cards from different manufacturers may also be better.
- ❑ The camera shop guy may be your friend, but he's primarily a businessman who gets a commission when you buy a camera from him. This commission differs from brand to brand, model to model. Don't take his word as the gospel truth when he tells you a particular model is good. Also, don't fall for the—"this-model-is-fast-moving-and-a-lot-of-my-customers-have-bought-it" thing. Check out the camera by taking a few shots. Most authorised dealers will have demo pieces with them. Remember: learn to demand—it's your money after all!
- ❑ Digital zoom specs are highly misleading, and you should learn to shy away from the term. Digital zoom is in fact not even a real zoom at all. Look at the optical zoom figure as a deciding factor as far as zooming goes.
- ❑ Most digital cameras today have a plethora of shooting options and settings. However, the layout of these settings—that is, the menu—varies a lot. Play around with the menu to see how intuitive it is. A clean menu structure with a clear hierarchy of options is what you should be looking for.
- ❑ Batteries are important no matter what kind of user you are. Better brands pay in the long run. The larger the mAh rating, the longer the battery will last. Good rechargeables outlast regular batteries 99 per cent of the time because they're rated for high-drain devices like toys and cameras. Alkaline batteries are deceptive—even high-rated batteries (by mAh rating) drain comparatively fast.
- ❑ In conjunction with point #1, if you plan to print your photos, the megapixel rating takes on more significance. For a 4" x 6" photo, look for a 4 MP camera. For an 8" x 10" photo, something in the range of 5 megapixels should do fine. 10" x 12" photos will demand 6 megapixels or above.

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